

CROOKED THINKING LEADS TO CROOKED BEHAVIOR

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Identify thoughts that trigger illegal behavior.
2. Create and implement positive thoughts that promote prosocial behavior.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Anger Management
- Antisocial Behavior

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The client may need assistance in working through this assignment. Explore his/her distorted thoughts that foster illegal behavior by reviewing past behavior and the thought process or basic beliefs that preceded the behavior. Help the client develop prosocial thoughts that foster adaptive, legal behavior choices.

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People take action based on thoughts that precede that action. These thoughts often serve to justify illegal behavior even when the thinking pattern is distorted and based in unreasonable beliefs. Use this assignment to identify your thinking pattern or beliefs that foster your engagement in illegal behavior.

1. Check off your distorted or unrealistic thoughts that foster breaking the law. Add your own thoughts if they are not listed.

___ I have to take things into my own hands to get what I want, regardless if it is illegal to do so.

___ I deserve to take what I want.

___ Other people get away with breaking the law; I should be able to do it, too.

___ The police are just out to get me.

___ If I get away without getting arrested, then the action was okay.

___ I don't have any choice; this action is my only alternative.

___ I *had* to do this to get out of a jam.

___ When I am drunk or high, I do crazy things that I'm not responsible for.

___ Life is not fair to me, so I have to break the law just to get by.

___ If I don't break the law, I will not fit in or get accepted.

___ .

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2. Replacing thoughts that trigger illegal behavior is hard work. You must catch yourself thinking the trigger thoughts and then talk to yourself in a more positive, prosocial, realistic manner. Focus on two of your trigger thoughts from the previous section and write several positive thoughts to replace the distorted ones.

Trigger Thought: _____

Positive Replacement Thoughts: _____

Trigger Thought: _____

Positive Replacement Thoughts: _____
